Duke | Political Science

UNDERGRADUATE COURSE

POLSCI 390-6

Logic of Domestic Politics

A formal and empirical approach to political behavior, institutions, and political outcomes



Why do political candidates sometimes adopt similar policy positions? How do interest groups influence public policy? Why do legislatures delegate authority to bureaucrats? What makes political leaders accountable to citizens? Why do some authoritarian regimes survive while others collapse?

This course introduces students to the formal analysis of domestic politics. We use game theory and data to examine how political actors make strategic decisions and how political institutions shape political outcomes.

TWO PATHS, A SHARED FOUNDATION

For Academic Research

Acquire the foundational skills to develop your own formal theoretical models, derive testable hypotheses, use empirical data to evaluate them, and complete a full research paper.

For Real-World Understanding

Gain a systematic framework for analyzing political behavior and institutions, explain why political actors make particular decisions, and critically evaluate competing explanations of political outcomes.

TOPICS INCLUDE

- Electoral competition
- Campaign finance and lobbying
- Legislative bargaining and agenda setting
- Delegation and bureaucracy
- Coalition formation and government
- Political agency and accountability
- Nondemocratic institutions
- Regime change and democratization

COURSE FORMAT

Lectures, model-solving exercises, and discussions of political applications

ASSESSMENT

Four problem sets	(50%)
Final research project	(40%)
Participation and engagement	(10%)

Syllabus: https://jiaweifu.org/pdf/syllabus_logic.pdf